However, the crisis intensified in Paris due to the high price of bread. Riots broke out. The women of Paris marched to Versailles to demand bread from the King. The crowd was in an aggressive mood. The crowd demanded that bread be provided to them. The royal family, including the King, was mobbed. They forced the King and the royal family to go with them to Paris.

Flight to Varennes

The King's position was increasingly shaky. He was not able to reconcile to the legislations passed by the National Assembly. He decided to escape from Paris. Dressing himself as a valet, he escaped along with his family to Varennes, a border town. However, he was recognized there by a postman, arrested by the National Guards and brought back to Paris. From then onwards, he remained in Paris virtually a prisoner.

Girondins and Jacobins

The moderate liberals wanted to keep the King as a limited monarch. They called themselves the party of the Girondins. The hardcore republicans were the Jacobins. In foreign countries especially in England, there were the émigrés, the French nobles who had run away from the Revolution and were continually intriguing against it. All the kings and emperors of Europe, who were frightened by this mass upsurge were ranged against revolutionary France.

Constitution of 1791

In September 1791, the National Assembly framed the first constitution. It provided for a Constitutional monarchy. The Legislature consisted of a single chamber of 750 members. The franchise was limited to those who owned a certain amount of property. The King continued to be the Executive head, but his powers were considerably limited. But the common people who had stormed the Bastille were disillusioned with the developments and found another outlet for their revolutionary energy. This was the Paris Commune. This Commune was in direct touch with the masses. The Commune became the rival of the National Assembly composed of the moderate middle class.


Marat

Emigres and the Revolutionary War

In August 1792 ordered an attack on the King's palace. Though the King ordered shooting by his Swiss guards, he was finally deposed and imprisoned. The people of Paris angered by the action of the Swiss guards in shooting and killing many of them hunted down the supporters of monarchy under their leader Marat. In three days, from September 2, about 1500 suspected dissidents were put in prison. After a trial, they were killed and this incident is called "September Massacres." In September also occurred the first victory of the French troops over the invading Austrians and Prussians at the battle of Valmy. This saved the Revolution. On September 21, 1792 the National Convention met.

National Convention and the Reign of Terror, June 1793-July 1794

The first action of the National Convention was to proclaim the formation of a republic. The trial of Louis XVI was taken up immediately and he was condemned to death. He was guillotined. From the very steps of the guillotine, Danton, a great leader of the Revolution, addressed the assembled crowds and threw an open challenge to other European kings. The new republic of France, through conscription, built up a strong army.


Danton

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